Documenting Migration

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The Courtauld

Critical Debates: *Migrations* - Portfolio

Documenting Migration

Concentration: MA History of Art: *Culture Wars: Art and Socialism Since 1917*

Professor(s): Group B: Chadwick / Mileeva

Word Count: 1,595

Art Is A Key Witness: Migration, Memory, and Identity in the Ben Uri Gallery Exhibition *From Adler to Żuławski: A Century of Polish Artists in Britain*

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Migration is a vibrant tapestry, intricately woven from countless stories of aspiration, adaptation, and ingenuity. It is not merely the physical transit of people, but a dynamic force that electrifies societies, infusing them with cultural vibrancy, sparking creative cross-pollination, and fueling both social and artistic evolution. Far from being a narrative of loss or displacement alone, migration orchestrates the convergence of traditions, perspectives, and talents, breathing new life into communities and reshaping their very foundations. The Ben Uri Gallery's *From Adler to Żuławski* exhibition vividly embodies this phenomenon, illuminating how Polish immigrant artists in Britain have, over the past century, sustained connections to their roots while simultaneously transforming the British art scene. Here, migration emerges as a wellspring of renewal, a catalyst for personal metamorphosis and collective cultural renaissance.

The Ben Uri Gallery's exhibition, *From Adler to Żuławski*, bursts with artistic vitality, serving as a living mosaic of migration's creative force. Each work on display is not just an artifact, but a pulsating testament to journeys undertaken, memories preserved, and identities reimagined. The immigrant artists featured do not merely recall their homelands; they channel the colors, textures, and rhythms of distant places into every brushstroke and sculpted form. Their art is alive with echoes of personal heritage, yet it simultaneously propels the British art scene into new territory, introducing bold visual languages and sparking exhilarating artistic dialogues. This exhibition transforms migration from an abstract concept into a dynamic, ongoing negotiation; a crucible where cultural memory and inventive spirit intermingle, forging unprecedented forms of expression and fostering a deeper, more nuanced understanding of belonging.

Among the gallery's luminaries are artists whose arrivals in Britain mirror the tumult and hope that so often define migration. Some escaped the chaos and devastation of World War II or

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fled oppressive regimes, seeking sanctuary and a canvas for renewal. Others journeyed by choice, driven by dreams of artistic mastery and new intellectual frontiers. Together, their stories weave a panorama of resilience, reinvention, and creative brilliance. Through their biographies, the exhibition unveils how both forced exile and voluntary migration entwine individual destinies with collective identity, compelling artists to balance the weight of their Polish-Jewish heritage with the challenges and opportunities of life in Britain. The evocative works of Józef Adler and Żuławski, for instance, shimmer with nostalgia and longing, yet also pulse with the vibrancy of new beginnings; inviting viewers to witness the enduring power of memory and the remarkable courage required to forge a renewed sense of self.

From Adler to Żuławski: A Century of Polish Artists in Britain foregrounds the phenomenon of migration while simultaneously celebrating the enduring influence these artists have exerted on both the British art scene and the narrative of Poland's 123 years of independence. The exhibition curates a constellation of stories that are not merely resonant or poignant but intellectually and emotionally compelling, revealing how artistic production can deeply transform historical trajectories and cultural memory. Furthermore, the exhibition subtly interrogates core migration paradigms by framing the journeys of Polish artists to Britain as complex, layered narratives, encompassing displacement, identity negotiation, and creative contribution. Through biographical, diasporic, cultural memory, and museological perspectives, the exhibition invites viewers to critically engage with the intricate processes through which art both reflects and constructs the lived realities of migration.

Although the exhibition refrains from explicitly narrating the impact of migration on British society, its curatorial approach subtly weaves this influence throughout the gallery space. The placards, artist bibliographies, and the artworks themselves collectively reveal the intense

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and enduring contributions of these Polish artists. Through nuanced references to their experiences and inspirations, the exhibition foregrounds how their creative legacies have indelibly shaped, and continue to inform, both the trajectory of British art and the broader historical discourse surrounding migration and cultural exchange.

While the exhibition as a whole elicits a rich spectrum of emotional and intellectual responses, several works distinguish themselves by their overpowering depth, intricate symbolism, and capacity to provoke sustained reflection: Shmuel Dresner's *Pages From The Diary Of David Rubinowicz* (2005)[28], Alicia Melamed-Adams's *Tears* (1993-20)[29], and Josef Herman's *Refugees* (c.1941)[30]. These pieces transcend mere representation, serving as visual palimpsests of the artists' lived encounters with the Holocaust; layering personal and collective trauma, memory, and resilience in highly evocative forms. Their compositions function as mnemonic devices, drawing the viewer into an immersive process of remembrance and critical engagement. Rather than simply portraying historical suffering, these works interrogate the mechanisms of memory, identity, and the transmission of collective tragedy through artistic practice, catalyzing vital discourse on the enduring ramifications of catastrophe within the visual culture of postwar Europe.

Shmuel Dresner, one of only seven hundred child survivors of the Holocaust to find refuge in England in 1945, employs a subtle yet impactful visual strategy in his work. Rather than overtly depicting the horrors of trauma, Dresner's approach is oblique, layering indirect

[28] Figure 1. Shmuel Dresner (1928-2019), *Pages From The Diary of David Rubinowicz* (2005), Collage on paper, 20 x 27.5 cm, Signed (lower left): 'S.D. 2005', Accession number 2015-01.
[29] Figure 2. Alicia Melamed Adams (1927-2022), *Tears* (1993), Mixed media on canvas, Unframed 80 x 63 cm, Framed 93 x 74 cm, Signed (lower right): 'Alicia Melamid', Accession number 1993-20. https://www.benuricollection.org.uk/search_result.php?item_id=815.
[30] Figure 3. Josef Herman (1911-2000), *Refugees* (c.1941), gouache on paper, Unframed 47 x 39.5 cm, framed 60.7 x 53.2 x 3.3 cm, Signed and titled on reverse of backing board 'Refugees by Josef Herman,' Accession number 2014-01.
https://benuri.org/exhibitions/17/works/artworks-1496-josef-herman-refugees-c.-1941/.

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references and symbolic gestures that allude to the tumult and oppression of the Nazi regime. His collage, *Pages From The Diary of David Rubinowicz* (2005)[31], incorporates historical markers such as the infamous May 10, 1933, book burning, and foregrounds Rubinowicz's own testimonial writings as a conduit for both personal and collective memory. Initiated in 1940, Rubinowicz's diary documents his persecution as a Jew and culminates tear-jerkingly in the joy of reunion with his father; an ephemeral happiness soon extinguished by his subsequent deportation and death at Treblinka.[32] Dresner's work thus transcends autobiography, transforming into a shared act of witness that redeems erased histories and restores agency to the silenced.[33] In an era when such experiences are only fleetingly addressed within formal education, the exhibition reasserts their urgency, inviting viewers to confront the legacies of survival and the ongoing struggle for communal remembrance within the Jewish diaspora.

Alicia Melamed-Adams's artwork *Tears* (1993-20) is notable for its chromatic intensity, employing a palette of vibrant hues that belie the gravity of its subject matter.[34] Subtle iconographic references, such as the depiction of the forget-me-not flower, native to Polish riverbanks, function as mnemonic anchors, ensuring the persistence of familial and communal memory. Initially, Melamed-Adams's artistic practice was characterized by somber, muted tones, yet over time she adopted a brighter visual language to evoke recollections of her family's Holocaust experiences. In *Tears* (1993-20),[35] the motif of weeping transcends the personal, serving as a visual synecdoche for collective mourning and the enduring imprint of trauma across

[31] Figure 1. Shmuel Dresner (1928-2019), *Pages From The Diary of David Rubinowicz* (2005).
[32] *Ben Uri Collection.* Shmuel Dresner. Ben Uri Collection. Accessed December 5, 2025.https://benuri.org/artists/143-shmuel-dresner/biography/.
[33] Abraham G. Duker, *Jewish Social Studies* 25, no. 1 (1963): 79–81. http://www.jstor.org/stable/4465965.
[34] *Ben Uri Collection*, Alicia Melamed-Adams, Ben Uri Collection, accessed December 4, 2025, https://www.benuricollection.org.uk/intermediate.php?artistid=262.
[35] Figure 2. Alicia Melamed Adams (1927-2022), *Tears* (1993).

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generations. The work thus operates on multiple registers, balancing a celebration of survival with the inescapability of loss.

Josef Herman's *Refugees* (c.1941) stands as a testament to the artist's engagement with the aesthetic and thematic legacies of Picasso, Chagall, Goya, and Käthe Kollwitz. Long believed lost for over six decades, the painting resurfaced, revealing layers of narrative complexity. Dominated by intense blue tones, an homage to Herman's Glasgow period, the composition evokes the erasure of Warsaw and the nocturnal melancholy of exile, with moonlight serving as a motif of longing and impermanence.[36] While deeply rooted in the iconography of Eastern European Jewish culture, *Refugees* (c.1941)[37] simultaneously extrapolates to universal themes of displacement, forced migration, and the existential uncertainties engendered by war. The enigmatic presence of a cat clutching a mouse, inspired by Picasso's *Cat Catching a Bird* (1939)[38], amplifies the painting's emotional resonance, symbolizing vulnerability, predation, and the pervasive anxieties of wartime existence. Herman's canvas thus becomes both a memorial to loss and a meditation on the fragility of belonging.

Adriana Swierszczek, herself and her family marked by the traumatic legacies of the Holocaust, German invasion, and Soviet occupation, offers in *Abduction of Europa* (2006)[39] a work of remarkable conceptual and visual sophistication. Positioned as a central axis of the exhibition, the piece lingers in the viewer's consciousness, especially through the placard's tantalizing suggestion that Europa may have escaped her fate. Drawing inspiration from Paul

[36] Phyllis Lassner. "The Art of Lamentation: Josef Herman's Humanist Expressionism." *Shofar (West Lafayette, Ind.)* 37, no. 3 (2019): 171–202. https://doi.org/10.1353/sho.2019.0034.
[37] Figure 3. Josef Herman (1911-2000), *Refugees* (c.1941).
[38] Figure 4. Pablo Picasso, Cat Catching a Bird (1939), Oil on canvas. 81 x 100 cm. Musée Picasso, Paris.
[39] Figure 5. Adriana Swierszczek, *Abduction of Europa* (2006), pencil and charcoal on paper 104 x 132 cm, signed (lower right): 'Adriana Swierszczek', 2008-7, Photo: Bridgeman images. Source: Ben Uri Gallery.

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Manship's sculpture and the ancient myth of Europa's abduction by Zeus, Swierszczek deploys myth as a critical lens for interrogating contemporary and historical violence.[40] The hypothetical escape of Europa destabilizes the foundations of European identity, raising questions about the continent's very genesis and the ethical implications of its mythic origins. Swierszczek's interpretation invites meditations on the trauma of displacement, the possibility of rebirth, as Europa is transformed from captive princess to queen of Crete, and the ongoing interplay of cultural hybridity across East and West. Her work thus operates as a palimpsest, layering ancient narrative, personal history, and political critique. Within the contexts of Britain and Poland, Princess Europa becomes a symbol of violated autonomy and cultural disruption; as in the myth, the continent's twentieth-century history is marked by power, deception, and forced migration. Swierszczek's *Abduction of Europa* (2006) ultimately reframes Europe itself as a site of contested memory, a metaphor for both the catastrophic ruptures and the imaginative possibilities wrought by migration, occupation, and the struggle for self-definition.

In summation, the Ben Uri Gallery's exhibition constitutes a significant intervention in the ongoing discourse surrounding migration, memory, and artistic agency. By curating works that traverse the liminal spaces between personal testimony and collective trauma, the exhibition *From Adler to Żuławski: A Century of Polish Artists in Britain* lays bare the critical role of visual culture in the construction and negotiation of diasporic identities. Through its sophisticated interplay of biography, myth, and historical narrative, the exhibition not only recuperates silenced histories and marginalized voices but also elucidates the mechanisms by which art operates as both witness and catalyst within processes of cultural transformation. Ultimately, the exhibition compels sustained critical engagement with how artistic practice mediates the

[40] *Europa*, Encyclopædia Britannica, accessed December 12, 2025, https://www.britannica.com/topic/Europa-Greek-mythology.

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complexities of displacement, belonging, and the continual rearticulation of identity across the shifting terrains of European history.

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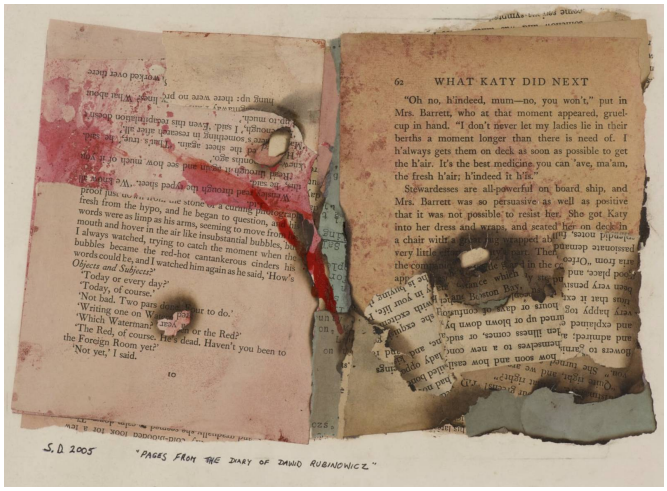


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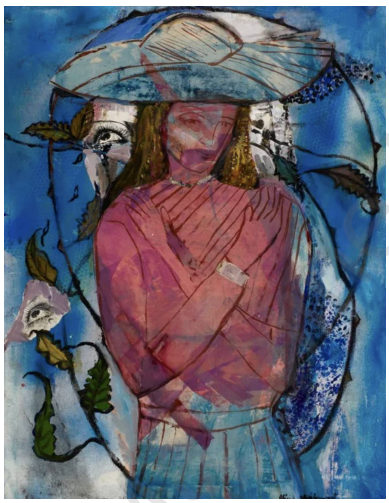


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